

Phillip Scott Ellis Green

THE MANY FACES OF
LOKEŚVARA: TANTRIC
CONNECTIONS IN
CAMBODIA AND CAMPĀ
BETWEEN THE TENTH
AND THIRTEENTH
CENTURIES

A Khmer tenth-century bronze of the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara currently held at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York provides considerable reason to pause and reflect on the current academic understandings of Buddhist traditions in early Cambodia (fig. 1).¹ Another Khmer depiction of Avalokiteśvara is not unusual in and of itself. The bodhisattva is well attested in art historical and epigraphical sources coming from Cambodia. What is intriguing is that this particular bronze depicts an early tantric manifestation of the bodhisattva known as Ekādaśamukha, the “eleven-faced” manifestation of Avalokiteśvara. The bronze has a conelike configuration of eleven heads and eleven pairs of arms, and the bodhisattva is seated in the *vajrāsana*. Scholars studying Avalokiteśvara in regions such as Nepal, China, and Japan

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¹ This bronze sculpture was acquired in 1987 and is listed in the Metropolitan Museum of Art’s online database. The piece is listed as having been acquired from the Margery and Harry Kahn Philanthropic Fund Gift in 1987 (accession number 1987.146). The piece is 18.7 centimeters (7 3/4 in.) high. Throughout this essay I use the term *Avalokiteśvara* as a mere scholarly convention; the word *Avalokiteśvara* is used only once in Cambodian epigraphy (K. 163), although abbreviated forms of this name are also known. By far the most commonly used denominations for Avalokiteśvara in the Khmer epigraphical record are *Lokeśa* and *Lokeśvara*.



FIG. 1.—Tenth-century Khmer bronze of Ekādaśamukha (image courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum of Art).

have long noted the bodhisattva's tantric associations and so-called esoteric forms. In Cambodia, however, Avalokiteśvara is rarely discussed or examined within a tantric context.² Instead, Avalokiteśvara is often described in academic works that mention the Buddhist traditions of the famous Angkorian period (from around the late eighth to the fifteenth centuries) in a generalized manner that tends to confine the bodhisattva to some kind of generic and universal Mahāyāna Buddhism. Perhaps one of the primary reasons for this

² Emma Bunker and Douglas Latchford's work *Adoration and Glory: The Golden Age of Khmer Art* (Chicago: Art Media Resources, 2004) devotes space to discussing tantric Buddhist art from Cambodia, but the piece from the Metropolitan Museum of Art is not mentioned, nor are there any connections made in the book between the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and tantric forms of Buddhism; their later *Khmer Bronzes: New Interpretations of the Past* (Chicago: Art Media Resources, 2011) incorporates new research and devotes more attention to tantric Buddhist influences, but only a few scant remarks connect Avalokiteśvara with these traditions (see esp. 176, 384). Nalanda Chutiwongs's indispensable work *The Iconography of Avalokiteśvara in Mainland South East Asia* (1984; New Delhi: Aryan Books International, 2002) remains the primary work on the art and iconography of Avalokiteśvara in Southeast Asia. Unfortunately, Chutiwongs could not discuss the piece from the Metropolitan, since her book was published before the museum acquired the bronze. Chutiwongs does discuss the sixteen-armed Avalokiteśvara bas-relief from Banteay Chhmar (ca. late twelfth to early thirteenth century); she does not associate this later depiction with any possible tantric connections, despite following Jean Boisselier's observations that some of the Banteay Chhmar bas-reliefs of Avalokiteśvara are likely connected with the *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, a text now known to contain tantric characteristics. Chutiwongs does, however, identify the presence of tantric Buddhism in Cambodia during the tenth and the early thirteenth centuries and notes its possible influence on other images of Avalokiteśvara (214–15, 246).

generalization is the lack of surviving manuscripts that would aid in understanding how the bodhisattva was viewed and worshipped at different times in Cambodia's past. Unlike, say, Nepal, Tibet, China, and Japan, where there are large bodies of surviving textual materials, there are no surviving Buddhist texts—or any other type of manuscript—from Cambodia's pre-Angkorian or Angkorian periods.³ This disparity means that the methodologies employed to uncover clues about Cambodia's early Buddhist traditions must differ from the methodologies used by scholars studying early forms of Buddhism in regions where there are surviving Buddhist texts.

To note that there are no surviving Buddhist texts from early Cambodia does not mean, however, that there are no surviving written records. While there are no surviving manuscripts (palm leaf, etc.), Cambodia does have a vast corpus of surviving epigraphical records composed primarily in Sanskrit and Old Khmer. Nevertheless, although the inscriptions written in Sanskrit often contain traditional opening panegyrics to gods and other powerful and efficacious beings (all of which provide important information on the religious traditions of the time), many of these epigraphical records are more concerned with praising the qualities and exploits of particular rulers and their favored ministers. In the case of the inscriptions in Old Khmer, the majority are concerned with recording property transactions, along with enumerating the donations connected with such property. Since the interested scholar is often provided only glimpses of religious thought and practice in the inscriptions, the epigraphical records must be examined in conjunction with Cambodia's impressive art historical record. By examining both sources, recognizing that these sources studied with respect to one another can provide more historical information than either source alone, the scholar can move beyond merely highlighting such things as royal genealogies and land transactions present in the epigraphy or simply identifying the iconography of a particular art historical piece.

By examining the epigraphical and art historical records of early Cambodia, as well as some of the epigraphical records from Campā, I argue that the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara goes from a relatively minor figure in Cambodia during the pre-Angkorian period to an increasingly important figure within an emerging tantric context beginning around the tenth century. Since it will be shown that Avalokiteśvara's increased importance in tenth-century Cambodia arose amid newly emerging strains of tantric Buddhism in the region, it is within this tantric context that we must begin to reassess the various ways in which this bodhisattva was understood.

³ By using the term *pre-Angkorian* I am broadly referencing the period prior to the time of Jayavarman II (r. 790–ca. 835), whose reign is commonly regarded as marking the transition between the pre-Angkorian period and the Angkorian period.

AVALOKITEŚVARA BEFORE THE TENTH CENTURY

Although Mahāyāna Buddhism was well established in Cambodia during the sixth through eighth centuries, in terms of extensive royal patronage it occupied a relatively minor position in the region when compared with forms of Śaivism and, to a lesser extent, Vaiṣṇavism.⁴ With specific regard to Avalokiteśvara, the surviving epigraphical record from Cambodia documents only two references to the bodhisattva prior to the mid-tenth century. The inscription of Ampil Rolum (K. 163)—dated on paleographic grounds to the sixth or seventh century⁵—cites donations to a Buddhist triad: Buddha, Maitreya, and Avalokiteśvara.⁶ The second reference occurs in the inscription of Kdei Ta Kom (K. 244), dated to Śaka 713 (791/792 CE).⁷ This latter inscription represents the first attested use of the epithet Lokeśvara (lord of the world) and records the installation of an image named Jagadīśvara (which also means “lord of the world”) in the likeness of Lokeśvara. The epithets of this inscription clearly invoke parallels with Śaivism, and such parallels only increase over time as the competition for royal patronage becomes more pronounced.

The earliest images of Avalokiteśvara in Cambodia are two-armed representations, although various configurations of two-armed and four-armed images are common throughout the pre-Angkorian period.⁸ Like the Kdei Ta Kom inscription above, many of these images display similarities with Śiva.⁹ Of

⁴ Ascertaining specifics regarding the forms of Buddhism (sects, texts used, rituals, persons involved, etc.) during the early periods in Cambodia is exceedingly difficult due to the limited nature of the evidence. Only a small amount of information can be gleaned from rare references to Buddhism in the epigraphy. Surviving images are more abundant, but this type of evidence has limitations. For a general overview of Buddhist traditions during the pre-Angkorian and other periods in Cambodia’s history, see Ian Harris, *Cambodian Buddhism: History and Practice* (Honolulu: University of Hawai’i Press, 2005).

⁵ Étienne Aymonier, *Le Cambodge*, vol. 1 (Paris: Leroux, 1900), 442.

⁶ George Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge*, 8 vols. (Paris: École française d’Extrême-Orient, 1954), 6:100–101. The actual terminology used is “vrah kammratān ’añ śāstā vrah kammratān ’añ maitreya vrah kammratān ’añ śrī avalokiteśvara.” All three names are prefixed with the Old Khmer *vrah kammratān ’añ*, a title used for divine beings and sometimes for pre-Angkorian kings. For more on this title, see Michael Vickery, *Society, Economics, and Politics in Pre-Angkor Cambodia: The 7th–8th Centuries* (Tokyo: Centre for East Asian Cultural Studies for UNESCO/Toyo Bunko, 1998), 143–49. Two points of interests should also be noted: (1) this inscription represents the only epigraphical use of this particular triad in Cambodia, and (2) the nomenclature *Avalokiteśvara* is never used again, although abbreviated forms of this name are used.

⁷ George Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge* (Paris: École française d’Extrême-Orient, 1942), 3:89. The entire inscription is as follows: “samagunaśaśinagaśake prathito yas supratīṣṭhito bhagavān / jagadīśvara iti nāmnā sa jayati lokeśvarapratimāḥ.” Alexis Sanderson (“The Śaiva Religion among the Khmers, Part I,” *Bulletin de l’École française d’Extrême-Orient* 90–91 [2003–4]: 349–463) provides the translation “Victorious is the renowned Lord well installed in Śaka 713 under the name Jagadīśvara in the likeness of Lokeśvara” (424 n. 277).

⁸ Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*, 232.

⁹ Ibid., 231; Chutiwongs also notes resemblances to Maitreya in the pre-Angkorian images of Avalokiteśvara.

special note are figures that have strong ascetic features such as wearing simple garments, wearing an antelope skin draped over the left shoulder, and holding a ritual water pot (*kamaṇḍalu*), an item sometimes used to perform ablutions.¹⁰

AVALOKITEŚVARA IN TENTH-CENTURY CAMBODIA

Although there are indications in the art historical record that by the eighth century Avalokiteśvara had become a somewhat independent figure deserving of special worship,¹¹ it was not until the tenth century that Avalokiteśvara truly garnered more widespread attention.¹² Perhaps one of the most important indications of this increased significance is a spike in the number of epigraphical references to Avalokiteśvara. As mentioned above, Avalokiteśvara is cited in only two inscriptions prior to the mid-tenth century. In the tenth century, however, this number jumps to at least thirteen, or 62 percent of all the inscriptions that include some reference to Avalokiteśvara in early Cambodia (table 1).¹³

¹⁰ The seventh-century bronze now in the National Museum of Cambodia in Phnom Penh is an excellent example of Lokeśvara displaying all these iconographic characteristics (inv. no. ga5332 [E 607, E/I 11,10]); see Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*, plate 106. Also of note is that strong similarities and connections between Śiva and Avalokiteśvara would in later time periods allow for easy manipulation of Avalokiteśvara images in order to somewhat crudely convert them to Śiva images. This was often accomplished by simply defacing the Amitābha image seated in the *jaṭāmukha* (crowned locks of hair). Two examples from the mid-eleventh century can be found in Bunker and Latchford, *Adoration and Glory*, 213–17, plates 70a, b, c, and 71.

¹¹ Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*, 219.

¹² I should be clear, however, by stating that Buddhist traditions occupied a clearly subordinate position during this period and would continue to do so until the reign of Jayavarman VII (r. 1182–ca. 1218).

¹³ The collective number of inscriptions in Cambodia referencing Lokeśvara from other centuries pales in comparison. Epigraphy is not the sole indicator of popularity or importance, especially due to the incomplete and sometimes fragmentary nature of the evidence. For example, while there are only four inscriptions making reference to Lokeśvara during the reign of Jayavarman VII (K. 485, K. 273, K. 908, and K. 1251), the sheer number of artistic representations of this figure during this period attests to the importance placed on the role of Lokeśvara in spite of a relatively limited amount of epigraphical evidence. I am purposefully setting aside the numerous epigraphical references of *kamrateñ jagats* from the twelfth century that variously incorporate the name Lokeśvara in mini-inscriptions found in locations such as the temple complex of Preah Khan. For example, these lists include such names as *kamrateñ jagat ratnalokeśvara* (S1. K. 907), *kamrateñ jagat śrīraṇādiyalokeśvara* (C20. K. 621), and *kamrateñ jagat śrīparamadiyalokeśvara* (C30. K. 907). For additional details concerning these later inscriptions, see George Coedès, “Études cambodgiennes XXXIX,” *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 44 (1951): 97–120, esp. 107–16. Additionally, I indicate that there are “at least thirteen” inscriptions from the tenth century referencing Avalokiteśvara because my preliminary research suggests that there may be more. For example, I believe the very fragmentary Phnom Banan inscription (K. 202) is probably from tenth century and that the fragmented word *-keśvara* found in the inscription was probably a reference to Lokeśvara. The details supporting my argument cannot be outlined here due to space constraints. Additionally, besides the possible reference to Lokeśvara the fragmentary content of the inscription contributes nothing further to this essay.

TABLE 1

TENTH-CENTURY CAMBODIA INSCRIPTIONS CONNECTED WITH AVALOKITEŚVARA

Inscription	Provenance	Date	Reference
K. 872	Prasat Beng Vien	944 CE	IC 5:97–104
K. 238	Toek Chum	949 CE	IC 6:119–22
K. 157	Vat Kdei Char	953 CE	IC 6:123–27
K. 266	Bat Chum	953 CE	JA 1908 (2): 213–52
K. 239	Prasat Kôk Samrong	966 CE	IC 3:79–84
K. 111	Vat Sithor	968 CE	IC 6:195–211
K. 417	Prasat Chikreng	970 CE	IC 2:48–50
K. 168	Prasat Chikreng	972 CE	IC 6:168–69
K. 240	Prasat Ta An	Tenth century	IC 3:76–77
K. 214	Phnom Banteay Neang	982 CE	IC 2:202–06
K. 452	Prasat Plang	988 CE	IC 5:156–57
K. 225	Thmā Puok	989 CE	IC 3:66–69
K. 1154	Unknown	Tenth century	NIC 2, and 3:129

SOURCES.—For the IC references, see George Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge*, 8 vols. (Paris: École française d'Extrême-Orient, 1937–54). For the JA reference, see George Coedès, “Les inscriptions de Bât Čum,” *Journal Asiatique* 10 (1908): 213–52. For a more recent translation and examination of the Bat Chum inscriptions, also see Jochen Mertens, *Die Sanskrit-Inschriften von Bat Chum (Kambodscha): Text mit Übersetzung und Kommentar und stilistischer Analyse* (Norderstedt: Herstellung und Verlag, Books on Demand, 2005). For the NIC reference, see Saveros Pou, *Nouvelles inscriptions du Cambodge*, vols. 2–3 (Paris: École française d'Extrême-Orient, 2002).

Three factors seem to be responsible for the increased interest in Avalokiteśvara during the tenth century. First, forms of Buddhism gained increasing recognition and support during the reigns of Rājendravarman (r. 944–ca. 966) and Jayavarman V (r. ca. 968–1000/1001). Second, new forms of Buddhism emerged and gained prominence in Campā during the late ninth and tenth centuries in which Avalokiteśvara played an important role, and interregional exchanges between the Khmers and Cams likely played a role in stimulating new forms of Buddhism in Cambodia. Third, Buddhist texts such as the *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra* (KVS) and the *Ekādaśamukhadhāraṇī* (EDMD), which focus on the virtues of Avalokiteśvara, may have increased the appeal of the bodhisattva in this region during the tenth century. Although both these texts predate the tenth century by many years, it is not until then that concepts and figures present in these texts are attested in Cambodia.¹⁴

¹⁴ As there are no surviving manuscripts from Cambodia, we cannot determine how closely related such texts would have been to the surviving manuscripts known today. Additionally, it must be admitted that the clues that lead us to determine that the Khmers likely had knowledge of the *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, and perhaps the *Ekādaśamukhadhāraṇī* as well, could be alluding to different texts with similar content that were circulating within the region.

The first factor regarding increased support during the reigns of Rājendrarman and Jayavarman V need not be elaborated here since arguments for increased recognition of Buddhism can be easily supported by reference to increased evidence in the epigraphical records of these respective rulers, and the third factor regarding the *KVS* and *EDMD* will be highlighted later in the essay. With regard to Campā, however, a few points should be highlighted now before focusing on Cambodia, since this factor specifically pertains to Avalokiteśvara and newly arising forms of tantric Buddhism in the region.

THE CAMPĀ STIMULUS

Buddhism had gained a prominent role among the ruling class during the late ninth and tenth centuries in Campā, and it is hard to imagine this popularity not spilling over into Cambodia beginning around the mid-tenth century with Rājendrarman.¹⁵ Around the mid- to late ninth century, the northern Campā polity (or polities) situated in and around the Thu Bồn river system, which is located in present-day Quảng Nam province in Vietnam, (re)gained political and economic significance with regard to maritime trade on the route between India and China. The dynasty associated with this region is frequently referred to as the Indrapura dynasty, after the Sanskrit name for an urban center associated with present-day Đông Dương.¹⁶ The extent of this dynasty's influence should not be limited to Quảng Nam province, since the epigraphical record indicates a zone of influence and control as far north as Quảng Bình.¹⁷

William Southworth has written that “with the return of trade to Guangzhou (Canton) in the late ninth century, the Thu Bon Valley again became economically dominant.”¹⁸ Surely disruptions and changes at China's end of the maritime routes would have directly affected this northern polity, but whatever the exact reason, based on the increased number of inscriptions in the region it seems clear that the area had achieved a certain level of political success and stability.

¹⁵ For an additional argument suggesting Khmer forms of Buddhism may have been influenced by Campā, see Ian Mabbett, “Buddhism in Champa,” in *Southeast Asia in the 9th to 14th Centuries*, ed. David Marr and A. C. Milner (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 1986), 289–314.

¹⁶ For problems in using the term *Indrapura* to denote the entire northern territory of Campā, see William Southworth, “Notes on the Political Geography of Campa in Central Vietnam during the Late 8th and Early 9th Centuries A.D.,” in *Southeast Asian Archaeology 1998*, ed. Wibke Lobo and Stefan Reimann (Hull: University of Hull Center for Southeast Asian Studies, 2000), 237–44.

¹⁷ Quảng Bình represents the northern-most region in which polities of Campā were located. Since I am focusing on the northern region in this essay, it should be noted that I am broadly referring to an area ranging roughly from Quảng Nam to Quảng Bình.

¹⁸ William Southworth, “Champa,” in *Southeast Asian: A Historical Encyclopedia, From Angkor Wat to East Timor*, vol. 3, ed. Keat Gin Ooi (Santa Barbara, CA: ABC-CLIO, 2004), 321–22.

What is most interesting about the inscriptions emerging during this period from the area ranging roughly from Quảng Nam to Quảng Bình is that they indicate that a form of Mahāyāna Buddhism was patronized by and privileged among the rulers. Prior to these inscriptions, the Cam epigraphical record from this northern region contains no references to Buddhism, although there are a few Buddhist-related Cam inscriptions that have come from the south.¹⁹ In short, the Cam epigraphical corpus from this area jumps from containing no Buddhist content to having at least six inscriptions containing overt Buddhist elements. These six inscriptions are listed in table 2.

I wish to highlight two facts concerning the Buddhist content of these inscriptions. First, Lokeśvara (i.e., Avalokiteśvara) is by far the most popular Buddhist

¹⁹ It was established in 1969 by Jean Filliozat ("L'inscription dite de 'Vô-Cạnh'," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 55 [1969]: 107–16) that the Vô Cạnh inscription (dated to the late third to fourth centuries CE) contains nothing explicitly Buddhist based on a reinterpretation of the name Śrī Māra contained in the inscription. For a more recent discussion of the inscription, see William Southworth, "The Origins of Campā in Central Vietnam, A Preliminary Review" (PhD thesis, SOAS, University of London, 2001), 198–205. I would like to stress, however, that there are other Cam inscriptions with undeniable Buddhist content south of Quảng Nam province. While I am not denying transregional connections and exchange between the northern polities of Campā and the southern ones, I am limiting my discussion to what the Cam inscriptions from the northern regions tell us. Nevertheless, for the sake of completeness, I include here a list of Cam inscriptions from the south that either predate, or are contemporary with, the northern inscriptions under discussion. A brief overview should make it clear that based on the epigraphy during this period Avalokiteśvara was not very influential in the south. Inscription C. 44 discovered in Phú Yên province is written on the back of a terra-cotta plaque bearing an image of the Buddha seated in meditation. The inscription contains a version of the *ye dharmā* verse inscribed in four lines. Henri Parmentier suggests the sixth-century Śaka as a possible date. A sandstone stele containing a Buddhist inscription was discovered in Phú Yên province at a site about one kilometer from where C. 44 was discovered. The stele probably dates to sometime in the seventh to ninth centuries. The stele bears an image of the Buddha on a lotus flower seated between two stūpas. The *ye dharma* verse is inscribed on the stele twice. For C. 44, see Henri Parmentier, "Nouvelles découvertes archéologiques en Annam," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 2 (1902): 280–82, and *Inventaire descriptif des monuments çams de l'Annam*, vol. 1, *Description des monuments* (Paris: Imprimerie nationale, 1909), 134, 137; and George Coedès and Henri Parmentier, *Listes générales des inscriptions et des monuments du Champa et du Cambodge* (Hanoi: Imprimerie d'Extrême-Orient, 1923), 12–13. On the stele, see Peter Skilling, William A. Southworth, and Trần K. Phương, "A Buddhist Stele from Mỹ Thạnh in the Phú Yên Province of Central Vietnam," in *Abhinandanamālā*, ed. Leelananda Prematilke (Bangkok: SPAFA Regional Centre of Archaeology and Fine Arts, 2010), 487–98. C. 23 from Ninh Thuận province, which is dated to 829/830 CE, records the donation of two temples, two monasteries, and land to both the Jina and Śaṅkara (i.e., the Buddha and Śiva) by a person named Samanta. The inscription was composed by his son, who was obviously Buddhist based on his name—Buddhanirvāṇa. The Sanskrit section was transcribed and edited by Auguste Barth and Abel Bergaigne in *Inscriptions sanscrites de Campā et du Cambodge* (Paris: Imprimerie nationale and Librairie C. Klincksieck, 1885–93), 237–41. For the Cam portion, see Étienne Aymonier, "Première étude sur les inscriptions tchames," *Journal Asiatique* 17 (1891): 5–86, esp. 25–27. The inscription C. 38 coming from the southern site of Pô Nagar in Khánh Hòa province can be mentioned insofar as it mentions that Bhadravarman's son, Indravarman, was familiar with the teachings of Jinendra (i.e., the Buddha). For C. 38, see Barth and Bergaigne, *Inscriptions sanscrites*, 258–60. Also see Edouard Huber, "Études indochinoises VIII–XII," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 11 (1911): 259–311, esp. 268–69.

TABLE 2

NINTH-CENTURY NORTHERN CAM INSCRIPTIONS WITH BUDDHIST-RELATED CONTENT

Inscription	Date	Province	Buddhist Content
C. 66	875 CE	Quảng Nam	Praises to Lokeśvara; founding of monastery
C. 171	Ninth century	Quảng Bình	Silver image of Ratnalokeśvara
C. 172	Ninth century	Quảng Bình	Mentions Jagadguru (epithet Buddha)
C. 138	902 CE	Quảng Nam	Praises Buddha, Lokeśvara, and Vajrapāṇi; installation of a Lokanātha image; mentions Pramuditlokeśvara monastery and unfamiliar tantric three-body doctrine
C. 149	911/912 CE	Quảng Trị	Founding of an Avalokiteśvara monastery
C. 167	914 CE	Kon Tum*	Installation of Mahīndralokeśvara

NOTE.—For C. 66, C. 138, and C. 149, see Claude Jacques, *Études épigraphiques sur le pays cham de Louis Finot, Édouard Huber, George Coedès et Paul Mus réunies par Claude Jacques* (Paris: École française d'Extrême-Orient, 1995), 41–57, 252–56, 273–85. For C. 171 and C. 172, see Louis Finot and Victor Goloubew, “Fouilles de Đai-hu (Quảng Bình, Annam),” *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 25 (1925): 469–75, esp. 472–75. For C. 167, see Louis Finot, “Lokeṣvara en Indochine,” *Études Asiatiques* 1 (1925): 227–56, esp. 234. The stone beam inscription of Ròn in Quảng Bình (C. 150), possibly from the early ninth century, is often cited as additional evidence from this period for the presence of Avalokiteśvara worship, and Buddhism in general (see Ian Mabbett, “Buddhism in Champa,” in *Southeast Asia in the 9th to 14th Centuries*, ed. David Marr and A. C. Milner [Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 1986], 289–314, esp. 300). The inscription records the donation of land on behalf of a figure called Ḍamareśvara (Lord of riots). In “Études indochinoises VIII–XII” (*Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 11 [1911]: 259–311, esp. 267), Edouard Huber claimed that Ḍamareśvara was another name for Avalokiteśvara inherited from Śiva. Ever since that time many scholars, myself included, have uncritically accepted Huber's observation, although Huber failed to support his claim with any evidence. Nandana Chutiwongs, and later Arlo Griffiths who supports Chutiwongs' position, have noted that the primary reason to associate the inscription with Buddhism is the inclusion of the word *vihāra* (monastery), and the fact that many of the northernmost Cam inscriptions are Buddhist; however, they both note that such reasons are not conclusive and the word *vihāra* may also refer to a Śaiva monastery. See Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*, 295; and Arlo Griffiths, Amandine Lepoutre, William A. Southworth and Thành Phần, *Văn khắc Chăm-pa tại Bảo tàng Điêu khắc Chăm-Đà Nẵng. The Inscriptions of Campā at the Museum of Cham Sculpture in Đà Nẵng* (Hanoi: École française d'Extrême-Orient; Ho Chi Minh City: Center for Vietnamese and Southeast Asian Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University Ho Chi Minh City and VNUHCM Publishing House, 2012), 235–36. Therefore, until additional evidence is put forth conclusively demonstrating that Ḍamareśvara refers to Avalokiteśvara I cannot include C. 150 with the other Buddhist inscriptions from the northernmost regions of Campā.

* The Kon Klor inscription (C. 167) remains unpublished; however, according to Finot (“Lokeṣvara en Indochine,” 234), the inscription was found on one of two ablution receptacles (*yonī*) found in the village of Kon Klor located in Kon Tum province. This province neighbors Quảng Nam province to the south(west). Based on its location, date and Buddhist content that record the installation of Mahīndralokeśvara by one Mahīndrādhipati, I think it should be grouped with the other inscriptions mentioned in the table.

figure among these six inscriptions. Lokeśvara—whether being praised, being erected in the form of an image, or simply nominally connected to the establishment of monasteries—is present in five of six inscriptions. Clearly the bodhisattva had become extremely popular during this period, whether worshipped alone or as part of the triad.²⁰ Only in the very short and fragmentary C. 172 is Lokeśvara absent.²¹ In addition to noting this inscription's fragmentary condition, it should also be noted that C. 172 was discovered in an enclosure near the temple of M̃y Đurc, and a stone image of Lokeśvara dating from the ninth or tenth century was discovered at this very temple in 1918; therefore, while Lokeśvara cannot be connected directly to this particular inscription, the bodhisattva can be connected to the temple where the inscription was discovered.²²

The second fact is the occurrence of some tantric elements in a couple of the inscriptions. By far the most significant is the An Thái inscription of 902 CE (C. 138). As has been noted by previous scholars, the end of this inscription contains an unfamiliar tantric tripartite configuration that bears some similarities to the concept of three Buddha families (*trikula*) elaborated in the early tantric text, *Mahāvairocanābhisambodhi Sūtra* (better known simply as the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra*).²³ The inscription reads:

This Vajradhātu which, although non-existent, is the cause of the Vajra-wielder (ie, Vajrapāṇi), became by the command of Śrī Śākyamuni, the abode of the Buddhas.

²⁰ For additional remarks on the Avalokiteśvara in Campā during this period, see Anne-Valérie Schweyer, "Buddhism in Campā," *Moussons* 13–14 (2009): 309–37. For similar practices in Cambodia, note the donation of an *āsrama* in Lokeśvara's name mentioned in the Khmer inscription of Ta An (K. 240), which is dated to Śaka 901 (979 CE). See Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge* 3:76–78.

²¹ The inventory schema begun by George Coedès is used throughout this article to reference the corpus of inscriptions from Cambodia and Campā. Inscriptions assigned a number prefix with "C." refer to Campā inscriptions and inscriptions prefixed with "K." refer to Khmer, or Cambodian, inscriptions. The first version was published in "Inventaire des inscriptions du Champa et du Cambodge," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 8 (1908): 37–92. A later supplement appeared in "Supplément à l'Inventaire des inscriptions," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 15 (1915): 173–80. The current standard is George Coedès and Henri Parmentier, *Listes générales des inscriptions et des monuments du Champa et du Cambodge* (Hanoi: Imprimerie d'Extrême-Orient, 1923). This was followed with two supplements that appeared in vols. 1 and 2 of Coedès's *Inscriptions du Cambodge*. At the time of writing this article, an EFEO project known as the *Corpus of Inscriptions of Campā* was in the process of updating the inventory of Campā inscriptions (<http://isaw.nyu.edu/publications/inscriptions/campa/about.html>).

²² This piece is now located in the Musée Guimet (MG 18899). For an image, see Pierre Baptiste and Thierry Zéphir, *Trésors d'art du Vietnam: La sculpture du Champa V^e–XV^e siècles* (Paris: Réunion des Musées Nationaux, 2005), 232, pl. 30.

²³ See Hiram Woodward, "A Review Article: Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia in the Light of Recent Scholarship," *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies* 35, no. 2 (2004): 329–54, esp. 345. For the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra*, see Rolf W. Giebel, *The Vairocanābhisambodhi Sūtra* (Berkeley, CA: Numata Center for Buddhist Translation and Research, 2005); and Stephen Hodge, *The Mahāvairocana-Abhisambodhi Tantra with Buddhaguhya's Commentary* (New York: Routledge-Curzon, 2003).

The Padmadhātu, the great non-existent, (but) the cause of Lokeśvara, became, by the logic of Amitābha's words, the abode of the Jinas.

This Cakradhātu, which, although beyond the state of non-existence, would be the cause of Vajrasattva, became, by the command of Vairocana, the third abode of the Jinas. (An Thái, C. 138, stanzas 8–10)²⁴

Scholars such as Nandana Chutiwongs have argued for a connection between the tripartite configuration in the An Thái inscription and the tenth-century treatise on tantric Buddhism from Java known as the *Saṅ Hyaṅ Kamahāyānikan* (*SHK*).²⁵ According to Kazuko Ishii, the *SHK* pantheon likely bears a close relation to the *Tattvasaṃgraha*—an important text of the Yogatantras—and the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* in that the Buddhist pantheon detailed in the *SHK* is composed of two groups that may have been associated with two *maṇḍalas*: the Garbhamaṇḍala of the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* and the Vajradhātumaṇḍala of the *Tattvasaṃgraha*.²⁶ The first group in the *SHK* comprises Śākyamuni, Vajrapāṇi, and Lokeśvara; while Vairocana, Akṣobhya, Ratnasambhava, Amitābha, and Amoghasiddhi (i.e., the Five Buddhas) make up the second group.

Another contemporary treatise on tantric Buddhism from Java is the *Saṅ Hyaṅ Kamahāyānan Mantranaya* (*SHKM*). Unlike the *SHK*, in which connections with the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* and the *Tattvasaṃgraha* can only be presumed based on certain corresponding similarities between the two, the connections between the *SHKM* and these two early tantric texts is beyond doubt, since the *SHKM* shares textual correspondences with both the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* and the *Tattvasaṃgraha*.²⁷ Whether the tantric concepts in the An Thái inscription from Campā were directly influenced

²⁴ Karl-Heinz Golzio, *Inscriptions of Campā: Based on the Editions and Translations of Abel Bergaigne, Etienne Aymonier, Louis Finot, Edouard Huber and Other French Scholars and of the Work of R. C. Majumdar; Newly Presented, with Minor Corrections of Texts and Translations, Together with Calculations of Given Dates* (Aachen: Shaker, 2004), 91–92.

²⁵ See Nandana Chutiwongs, “Le Bouddhisme du Champa,” in Baptiste and Zéphir, *Trésors d'art du Vietnam*, 65–87, esp. 80–81; and Schweyer, “Buddhism in Ćampā,” 315–16. Regarding the *SHK* and *SHKM*, see Lokesh Chandra, “Saṅ Hyaṅ Kamahāyānan Mantranaya,” in *Cultural Horizons of India*, vol. 4 (New Delhi: International Academy of Indian Culture and Aditya Prakashan, 1995), 295–434. Chandra provides a list of the previous scholarship pertaining to these two texts.

²⁶ See Kazuko Ishii, “Borobudur, the *Tattvasaṃgraha*, and the *Saṅ Hyang Kamahāyānikan*,” in *The Art and Culture of South-East Asia*, ed. Lokesh Chandra (Delhi: Aditya, 1991): 151–64, esp. 158–59.

²⁷ See, e.g., J. de Jong, “Notes on the Sources and the Text of the *Saṅ Hyang Kamahāyānan Mantranaya*,” *Bijdragen tot de Taal-, Land- en Volkenkunde* 130, no. 4 (1974): 465–82; Kazuko Ishii, “The Correlation of Verses of the *Saṅ Hyang Kamahāyānan Mantranaya* with Vajrabodhi's *Jāpa-sūtra*,” *Area and Culture Studies* 44 (1992): 225–36, and “Borobudur, the *Tattvasaṃgraha*, and the *Saṅ Hyang Kamahāyānikan*.” Ishii notes that verses 12 and 13 of the *SHKM* correspond to the *Tattvasaṃgraha* (i.e., the *Sarvatathāgatatattvasaṃgraha*).

by the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* and the *Tattvasaṃgraha*, or whether they were indirectly influenced by these early tantric texts by way of contemporary tantric treatises like the *SHK* and *SHKM* coming from Java, cannot currently be determined with any real certainty. When we additionally consider, however, that the *Tattvasaṃgraha* is specifically cited in a later tenth-century inscription from Cambodia (Vat Sithor, K. 111), it appears certain that some of the tantric concepts found in the *Mahāvairocana Sūtra* and the *Tattvasaṃgraha* were influential in not only Java but in Campā and Cambodia as well.²⁸

Brief mention should also be made of the Nham Biền stele inscription of 911/912 CE (C. 149) from the above list of six inscriptions, although there are difficulties to attributing any tantric Buddhist connection to this particular record.²⁹ In this inscription an individual named Rājadvāra undertook (twice) some kind of diplomatic mission (*dūtakarman*) to Yavadvīpapura (Java) as a result of which he obtains *siddhayātrā*.³⁰ Later in his career, Rājadvāra—who

²⁸ I will return to the Vat Sithor inscription later in the essay. For the inscription, see Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge* 6:195–211. Stanza 29 mentions the *Tattvasaṃgraha*: “lakṣaṅgrantham abhiprajñam yo nveṣya pararāṣṭrataḥ tattvasaṅgrahaḥkāditantrañ cādhyāpayad yamī” (The one who had subdued his senses [Kīrtipaṇḍita], having sought from abroad the *Lakṣaṅgrantha Prajñāpāramitāsūtra* and the *Tattvasaṅgrahaḥkāditantram*, taught [them]). For the emended reading regarding *lakṣaṅgrantham*, see Sanderson, “Saiva Religion among the Khmers,” 427 n. 284. Furthermore, Sanderson takes *tattvasaṅgrahaḥkāditantrañ* to mean that Kīrtipaṇḍita taught the “Tantra teachings [tantram] of such texts as the *Tattvasaṃgraha* and its commentary.”

²⁹ Arlo Griffiths, Amandine Lepoutre, William A. Southworth, and Thành Phần (“Épigraphie du Campā 2009–2010: Prospection sur le terrain, production d’estampages, supplément à l’inventaire,” *BEFEO* 95–96 [2012]: 435–97) note that the correct spelling of the place of origin for C. 149 is unknown; this has resulted in institutions and scholars employing various spellings (447).

³⁰ The correct Sanskrit for stanza 8 is “yavadvīpapuraṃ bhūpānujñāto dūtakarmanṇi gatvā yaḥ pratipattisthaḥ siddhayātrām samāgamat.” The term *dūtakarman* (specifically, *dūtakarmanṇi* in the inscription) deserves a few remarks since the term *nūtakarmanṇi* from Edouard Huber’s reading continues to be cited in sources. In 1911 Huber published a transcription and French translation of this inscription (“Études indochinoises VIII–XII,” 299–311). He also included plates of the estampages that he used. Stanza 8 occurs on lines eleven and twelve on side A of the stele. Huber provided the following transliteration: “Yavadvīpapuraṃ bhūpānujñāto nūtakarmanṇi gatvā yaḥ pratipattisthaḥ siddhayātrām [read as *siddhayātrām*] samā(12)gamat,” which he translated as, “Pour un but louable [i.e., *nūtakarman*], lui qui est ferme de propos, il se rendit, avec l’autorisation du roi, dans la capitale de Java où il acquit la science magique” (309). In 1927, R. C. Majumdar objected to Huber’s reading of *nūta*-, writing that “Huber translates ‘Siddhayātrām Samāgamat’ as ‘acquired the science of magic.’ This seems to be farfetched. Huber reads ‘nūta’ in the first line of the verse, which seems to be a mistake for ‘dūta’.” “Nūta” means ‘praiseworthy’—so it also leads nearly to the same conclusion” (*Ancient Indian Colonies in the Far East*, vol. 1, *Champa* [Lahore: Punjab Sanskrit Book Depot, 1927], 134 n. 3); Majumdar translated the Sanskrit as “At the command of the king he went to the capital of Yavadvīpa on a diplomatic mission [i.e., *dūtakarman*], and obtained credit by the success of his undertaking.” Huber’s transcription and interpretation was followed by Golzio in his more recent English synthesis of the work done on the inscriptions of Campā in 2004 with a note referencing Huber’s alternate translation of *siddhayātrā* (Golzio, *Inscriptions of Campā*, 112). Majumdar’s initial suspicion is correct; according to Mabbett (“Buddhism in Champa,” 302), Majumdar’s reading was confirmed in a personal communication with Claude Jacques, who had access to the estampage in Paris. After I examined a decent-

had become very successful and wealthy in his duty to the king—installed and consecrated Devaliṅgeśvara (i.e., Śiva) in a temple, and later still he established a monastery dedicated to Avalokiteśvara. Much has been written on the term *siddhayātrā*—which occurs in several inscriptions from Southeast Asia—and this has led to various interpretations over the years.³¹

In short, the interpretations can be divided into three camps: (1) those that interpret *siddha* in the context of the inscriptions as pertaining to the acquisition of some kind of magical powers; (2) those that understand *siddha* in a much more secular sense pertaining simply to success or victory in some kind of undertaking; and (3) those that attempt to reconcile these two positions by indicating that *siddha* in the context of the inscriptions pertains to the acquisition of magical power necessary to ensure success or victory. All three interpretations maintain that such magical powers or success were acquired by means of a pilgrimage or journey (*yātrā*).

So, for example, adopting Edouard Huber's interpretation of the expressions *siddhayātrām samāgamat* and *siddhayātrām upāgamat* from the Nham Biền inscription as "acquired the science of magic," George Coedès concluded in 1930 that *siddhayātrā* "designates a journey or pilgrimage from which the pilgrim returns invested with supernatural powers."³² This was also the basic position of N. J. Krom.³³ B. C. Chhabra, however, felt such interpretations were doubtful due to an unnecessary conflation between *siddhi* and *siddha* and argued that *siddhayātrā* referred simply to a successful voyage, much like R. C. Majumdar, who translated the Nham Biền inscription's *siddhayātrām samāgamat* as "obtained credit by the success of his undertaking."³⁴ Attempting to reconcile these positions, Willem Stutterheim—and later Boechari, who adopted Stutterheim's interpretation—concluded that *siddhayātrā* referred to a "pilgrimage of victory," which he further elaborated

quality image of the estampage provided by Arlo Griffiths on May 27, 2011, it became clear that there is no difference between the *d* in *tadā* in line 10 and the *d* in *dūta* in line 11. In an e-mail communication on June 2, 2011, this reading of *dūta* was confirmed by Amandine Lepoutre, who was able to provide high-quality photographs of the stone in Hanoi. Arlo Griffiths has also brought to my attention the use of *dūta* in the stele of Bàng An (C. 141, line 14) that is contemporary with C. 149. I sincerely thank both Arlo Griffiths and Amandine Lepoutre for their assistance in (re)confirming what R. C. Majumdar suspected over eighty years ago.

³¹ For an in-depth overview and a survey of the various interpretations on *siddhayātrā* in South-east Asian inscriptions, see K. A. Nilakanta Sastri, "Siddhayātrā," *Journal of the Greater India Society* 4 (1937): 128–36.

³² Huber, "Études indochinoises VIII–XII," 309; and George Coedès, "The Malay Inscriptions of Sriwijaya," repr. and trans. in *Sriwijaya: History Language of an Early Malay Polity*, ed. Pierre-Yves Manguin and Mubin Sheppard (1930; Kuala Lumpur: Monograph of the Malaysian Branch Royal Asiatic Society, 1992), 41–92, esp. 62.

³³ N. J. Krom, *Hindoe-javaansche geschiedenis* (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1931), 121.

³⁴ Bahadur Chand Chhabra, *Expansion of Indo-Aryan Culture during Pallava Rule* (Delhi: Munshi Ram Manohar, 1965), 25–26. Majumdar, *Ancient Indian Colonies*, 134.

as “a pilgrimage on which one sets out to obtain the magic power necessary for a victory.”³⁵

In his examination of the *Pañcatantra* and the *Jātakamālā*—both of which contain expressions using *siddhayātrā*—K. A. Nilakanta Sastri concluded that the previous interpretations connecting *siddhayātrā* with something mystical or magical were not far-fetched at all (contrary to the views of scholars such as Chhabra and Majumdar).³⁶ In fact, based on the usage of the term in these two earlier texts, he states, “It seems clear therefore that *siddhayātrā* in the Indonesian inscriptions is a technical phrase with unmistakable reference to the acquisition of magic power of some sort or other.”³⁷ While Coedès, unlike Krom, was not absolutely convinced that there was necessarily a relationship between tantric forms of Buddhism in these regions and the importance of *siddhi* (magic) he did write that “what we can say is that magic, which since prehistoric times must have been very important among the primitive Indonesian populations, was more easily reconciled with Hinduist or Buddhist Tantrism than with any other religion.”³⁸

Ignoring the problems and assumptions that could be associated with the word *magic* in the context of Buddhist rituals, Coedès does have a point that such rituals involving the acquisition of power or magic may have been more easily accommodated by certain tantric rites. With that said, however, it has yet to be proven that the rites associated with performing a *siddhayātrā* were

³⁵ The quotes from Willem Stutterheim’s, “Verslag over de gevonden inscripties” (in *Oudheidkundige vondsten in Palembang* [Palembang: Ebeling, 1935]) are quoted from Boechari, “An Old Malay Inscription of Śrīwijaya at Palas Pasemah (South Lampung),” in *Melacak Sejarah Kuno Indonesia Lewat Prasasti: Tracing Ancient Indonesian History through Inscriptions* (Jakarta: Kepustakaan Populer Gramedia, Universitas Indonesia, & École française d’Extrême-Orient, 2012), 361–84, 378. Stutterheim’s thoughts on *siddhayātrā* are also summarized in Sastri, “Siddhayātrā,” 130–31. For Boechari’s thoughts on *siddhayātrā* in relation to the Kedukan Bukit inscription from Sumatra, see “New Investigations on the Kedukan Bukit Inscription,” in *Melacak Sejarah Kuno Indonesia Lewat Prasasti: Tracing Ancient Indonesian History through Inscriptions* (Jakarta: Kepustakaan Populer Gramedia, Universitas Indonesia, & École française d’Extrême-Orient, 2012), 385–99, esp. 389–92. Boechari also stressed the implications of the king in the Kedukan Bukit inscription embarking on the eleventh day of the bright part of the month of Waiśākha: “It is well known that the day of pūrṇamā of Waiśākha is a holy day for the Buddhists; it is considered as the day of the birth as well as the enlightenment and nirvāṇa of the Buddha. We are of the opinion that on that day Dapunta Hyān went by ship to a Buddhist shrine, perhaps upstream on the Batang Kuantan, to celebrate the Waiśākha festivals, at the same time praying and giving offerings for the success of his coming military expedition” (“Old Malay Inscription,” 378). This led Boechari to conclude that *siddhayātrā* (i.e., the journey to the Waiśākha festival where prayers for success were performed) referred to a Buddhist pilgrimage (378; see also “New Investigations,” 389, 392).

³⁶ Chhabra (*Expansion of Indo-Aryan Culture*) was the first to analyze *siddhayātrā* in the context of the *Pañcatantra* and *Jātakamālā*, but he obviously arrived at a different conclusion than Sastri (“Siddhayātrā”).

³⁷ Sastri, “Siddhayātrā,” 135.

³⁸ Coedès, “Malay Inscriptions of Sriwijaya,” 62–63.

connected with tantric practitioners and texts, although it is certainly possible. Therefore, additional research on the term *siddhayātrā* is still needed.³⁹

THE AVALOKITEŚVARA PARALLEL

While no explicit connection can be made with Cambodia from the above Cam inscriptions, a similar pattern, however, seems to occur in the Cambodian epigraphy from the tenth century—namely, there is a contemporaneous increased presence of Avalokiteśvara in the Cambodian epigraphy, as well as newly arising tantric elements, that roughly parallel the Cam epigraphical record. As mentioned previously, Avalokiteśvara is cited in only two Khmer inscriptions prior to the mid-tenth century, but epigraphical references to the bodhisattva jump to at least thirteen, or roughly 62 percent, of all the inscriptions that include some reference to Avalokiteśvara in early Cambodia.

Recall that similarly in the northern regions of Campā there are no inscriptions mentioning Avalokiteśvara prior to 875 CE (C. 66), but then between the late ninth century and the early tenth century (914 CE, C. 167) the number jumps to five inscriptions connected with the bodhisattva. This is not to imply that in either Cambodia or Campā the bodhisattva was unknown before this period (which is clearly not the case in either region, based on the art historical records) but merely to highlight that in both regions there is a roughly contemporaneous spike in the epigraphy likely indicating increased worship of the bodhisattva and overall royal support of forms of Mahāyāna Buddhism previously unknown for both regions.

THE TANTRIC CONNECTION IN TENTH-CENTURY CAMBODIA

Also noteworthy is that the first attested signs of Buddhist tantric elements that constitute an important aspect of the type of Mahāyāna Buddhism during this period arise in Cambodia during the tenth century, again roughly following the first attested presence of Buddhist tantric elements in the northern regions of nearby Campā (e.g., An Thái, C. 138). For example, we should note that triads consisting of the Buddha, Avalokiteśvara, and Vajrapāṇi first appear in Cambodia in the tenth century.⁴⁰ This is a well-known triad within

³⁹ For more on the term *siddhayātrā*, see J. G. de Casparis's remarks in *Prasasti Indonesia II: Selected Inscriptions from the 7th to 9th Century A.D.* (Bandung: N.V. Masa Baru, 1956). An additional relevant reference (as noted in Woodward, "Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia," 336 n. 14) is Hermann Kulke, "'Kadātuan Śrīvijaya'—Empire or Kraton of Śrīvijaya? A Reassessment of the Epigraphical Evidence," *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 80 (1993): 159–80.

⁴⁰ For example, a triad of the Buddha, Lokeśvara, and Vajrapāṇi is specifically invoked in K. 266 (Bat Cum, Southern Shrine); see George Cœdès, "Les inscriptions de Bât Cum," *Journal Asiatique* 10 (1908): 213–52; and Jochen Mertens, *Die Sanskrit-Inschriften von Bat Chum (Kambodscha): Text mit Übersetzung und Kommentar und stilistischer Analyse* (Norderstedt: Books on

Mahāyāna Buddhism in many regions outside of Cambodia, and such a triad does not necessarily imply tantric connections or meanings. The timing with which this triad appears in Cambodia, however, suggests that such a configuration was influenced by contemporary tantric ideas and forms of practice in regions such as Campā and Java.⁴¹ As such, Avalokiteśvara is understood to belong to the lotus family (*padma-kula*), while Vajrapāṇi belongs to the vajra family (*vajra-kula*). An excellent representation of this triad in Cambodia comes from the tenth-century sculptures discovered in Kampong Cham and now located in the Musée Guimet.⁴² Also note that Vajrapāṇi first appears in the Cam epigraphy in 902 CE (C. 138) couched in a clear tantric tripartite context. With regard to Java, the tenth-century tantric *SHK* may again be of interest in that Śākyamuni, Lokeśvara, and Vajrapāṇi are often configured together in various ways, as when they are equated with the Three Jewels of Buddhism and combined the five Buddhas: “The holy Śākyamuni has, in truth, the holy Buddha as his essence (*tatva*), Śrī Lokeśvara has the holy Dharma as his essence, Bajrapāṇi has the venerable Saṅgha as his essence. They are called bhaṭāra Ratnatraya. Vairocana, Amitābha and Akṣobhya are called Ratnatraya. Vairocana, Ratnasambhava and Amoghasiddhi are also Ratnatraya.”⁴³

The tenth-century Vat Sithor inscription (K. 111) provides stronger evidence for a tantric presence in tenth-century Cambodia.⁴⁴ Among other things, this inscription indicates that the learned Kīrtipaṇḍita traveled abroad for texts such as the *Tattvasaṃgraha* (i.e., the *Sarvatathāgatattattvasaṃgraha*), a key text of the Yogatantras.⁴⁵ The inscription is also clear that both exoteric (*vāhya* = *bāhya*) and esoteric (*guhya*) forms of Buddhism were taught and

Demand, 2005). The earliest epigraphical reference to this triad in Southeast Asia that I am aware of comes from the eighth-century Nakhon Si Thammarat inscription dated to 775 CE. See George Coedès, “The Kingdom of Sriwijaya,” and “The Inscription on the Ligor Stone: The Current State of its Interpretation,” both repr. and trans. in *Sriwijaya: History Language of an Early Malay Polity*, ed. Pierre-Yves Manguin and Mubin Sheppard (1918; Kuala Lumpur: Monograph of the Malaysian Branch Royal Asiatic Society, 1992), 1–40, esp. 23–25, and 103–11, respectively.

⁴¹ Here I would like to point readers to Arlo Griffiths, “An Inscribed Bronze Sculpture of a Buddha in *bhadrāsana* at Museum Ranggawarsita in Semarang (Central Java, Indonesia),” *Arts Asiatiques* (forthcoming). Among other things, in this article Griffiths has suggested that the iconography of Buddha, Avalokiteśvara, and Vajrapāṇi images in South and Southeast Asia may be a reflection of the triadic arrangement described in tantric Buddhist texts such as the *Susiddhikarasūtra* and the *Mañjuśrīyamūlakalpa*. I am grateful to Arlo Griffiths for sharing a draft of his paper with me.

⁴² For images, see Pierre Baptiste and Thierry Zéphir, *L’Art Khmer dan les Collections du Musée Guimet* (Paris: Réunion des Musées Nationaux, 2008): 166–71.

⁴³ Chandra, “Saṅ Hyañ Kamahāyānan Mantranaya,” 425.

⁴⁴ Another good example indicating a probable tantric presence in tenth-century Cambodia would be the archaeological discovery of the remains of a *prastāra* (letter diagram) at the three brick shrines of Bat Cum. For instance, see George Coedès “Un *yantra* récemment découvert à Angkor,” *Journal Asiatique* 4 (1952): 465–77. For the most recent examination on this diagram, see Hiram Woodward, “Bianhong, Mastermind of Borobudur?,” *Pacific World*, no. 11 (2009): 25–30, esp. 30–32.

⁴⁵ For more on this topic, see Sanderson, “Śaiva Religion among the Khmers,” 427.

propagated during this period (stanza 42). Furthermore, worthy officiants had to be “adept in the heart[-syllable]s, Muḍrās, Mantras, and Vidyās, and the ritual of the fire-sacrifice,” and they also had to “understand the secret doctrines of the Vajra and the Bell” (stanza 69).⁴⁶ Within this tantric context, the inscription also details how Kīrtipaṇḍita reinstalled images of Vajrin (i.e., Vajrapāṇi) and Lokeśa (i.e., Avalokiteśvara) on a mountaintop (stanza 45). This highlights the continuing importance and role of Avalokiteśvara during a time when tantric forms of Buddhism were becoming prevalent in Cambodia. While the actual extent of tantric Buddhism during this time could be a matter of dispute, such overt references in the epigraphical record leave little doubt as to its actual presence in the region.

THE ELEVEN-HEADED AVALOKITEŚVARA

As mentioned earlier, tenth-century Cambodian conceptions of Avalokiteśvara may have been influenced by concepts found in the *EDMD*, a text connected with the early development of the Mantranaya movement that extols Avalokiteśvara in his eleven-faced form.⁴⁷ The strongest evidence for this claim comes from both epigraphical and art historical sources. With regard to the latter, a Khmer bronze figure of Ekādaśamukha was discovered in 1979 in the village of Wat Khanun, Thailand.⁴⁸ This figure has eleven heads and eleven pairs of hands and stands on the stamen of a lotus. The heads are arranged in three tiers: a main head on lowermost tier, seven heads on the sec-

⁴⁶ Stanza 69: “hṛnmuḍrāmantravidyāsu homakarmmaṇi kovidaḥ / bajraghaṇṭārahasyajñō dakṣiṇīyaḥ purohitaḥ,” trans. and emended reading from Sanderson, “Śaiva Religion among the Khmers,” 427 n. 284. It may also be worthwhile to highlight that stanzas 44 and 45 claim that in order to continue the lineage of Sarvavid an image of Prajñāpāramita was erected and ten images of Avalokiteśvara (Lokeśa) and Vajrapāṇi (Vajrin) were repaired. *Sarvavid* is an epithet meaning “all-knowing” and “omniscient,” and is often used to refer to the Buddha, or a buddha. However, *Sarvavid* is also an epithet often specifically used for Vairocana, a possibility that would not be out of context in this inscription. The Sanskrit of stanzas 44–45 is “tatsthāne sthāpitā sthityai sarvavidvaṇśabhāsvataḥ / prajñāpāramitā tāṛi janāni yena tāyinām // śrīsatyavarmmaṇā bajrilokeśārccā daśādhikāḥ / stāpitāḥ prāḡ girau bhagnāsānā yo tiṣṭhipat punaḥ” (Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge* 6:199).

⁴⁷ For an edited copy of the Gilgit manuscripts (dated to between the fifth and sixth centuries), see Nalinaksha Dutt, *Gilgit manuscripts*, vol. 1 (Delhi: Sri Satguru, 1984), 59–60. For an English translation of the Yaśogupta’s translation into Chinese, which was completed sometime between 564 and 572 CE, see Donald Wood, “The Eleven Faces of the Bodhisattva” (PhD diss., University of Kansas, 1985), 360–73. For an English translation of Amoghavajra’s (705–74 CE) expanded and elaborated version of the text (*Shiyi mian Guanzizai pusa xin miyan yigui jing*, “The Sūtra of the Eleven-headed Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva Heart Secret Mantra Rituals”), see Eric Grinstead and Henrik Sørensen, “The Sūtra of the Eleven-Headed Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva,” in *The Esoteric Buddhist Tradition*, ed. Henrik H. Sørensen (Copenhagen: Seminar for Buddhist Studies, 1994), 97–125.

⁴⁸ Piriya Krairiksh, *Art in Peninsular Thailand Prior to the Fourteenth Century A.D.* (Bangkok: Amarin, 1980), 66 and 202. I must thank Hiram Woodward for bringing this piece to my attention.

ond tier, and three heads on the uppermost tier. The two primary hands are missing, but the other ten pairs display the *abhayamudrā* (do-not-fear gesture). Overall, the artistic arrangement of the *sambat* and other Khmer features are related to the Koh Ker style (921–45 CE).⁴⁹

A higher-quality image of the above mentioned bronze discovered at Wat Khanum was later published in 2012 alongside yet another Khmer bronze Ekādaśamukha also dating from the tenth century.⁵⁰ This second piece is currently held in a private collection. In addition to having eleven heads, the bronze is standing, has only four arms, and appears to conform to the early Khleang style of Khmer art that typically dates from the mid-tenth to the early eleventh century. Unfortunately the provenance of this piece is unknown. This variation can also be seen in another four-armed Ekādaśamukha Khmer bronze documented as having sold at a Christie's art auction in September 2000.⁵¹ This third bronze is standing and also dates from the tenth century. As with the other four-armed bronze, the provenance of this piece is unknown.

Finally, a fourth bronze image of an eleven-headed Avalokiteśvara dating from around the tenth century was acquired by the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York in 1987 and was mentioned in the opening of this essay (fig. 1). This piece has yet to appear in publication, which highlights the continuing neglect of this early tantric form in studies pertaining to Buddhist traditions in early Cambodia. Like the bronze discovered in Wat Khanun, this piece has a similar conelike configuration of eleven heads and eleven pairs of arms. Unlike the previously mentioned pieces, however, this figure is seated in the *vajrāsana* instead of standing.⁵²

Regarding the epigraphical evidence, the Prasat Chikreng inscription (K. 168) of 972 CE contains an opening invocation to Ekādaśamukha, Lokeśvara, and Bhagavatī (Prajñāpāramitā).⁵³ This inscription has attracted little schol-

⁴⁹ Ibid. 66. Krairiksh notes that the feature that appears to indicate an exception to the Koh Ker style is the loop on the left side, which he claims are remnant of the preceding Bakheng style (893–925 CE).

⁵⁰ Piriya Krairiksh, *The Roots of Thai Art* (Bangkok: River Books, 2012), 292. The caption in the text also postulates that the arrangement of the heads may be influenced by Chinese eleven-headed Avalokiteśvara images. I thank Joseph Bauerschmidt for bringing this bronze, as well the bronze that sold at Christie's in 2000, to my attention.

⁵¹ Fred Stern, "Art from the East," <http://www.artnet.com/Magazine/reviews/stern/stern10-27-00.asp>. This piece also appeared in Spink and Son, *A Divine Art: Sculpture of South East Asia* (London: Spink, 1997), 28–31.

⁵² I currently know of no other eleven-headed sculptures of Avalokiteśvara connected with the Khmers from the tenth century. There are, however, eleven-headed Prajñāpāramitās (?) dated to the eleventh and twelfth centuries. For an example, see Baptiste and Zéphir, *L'Art khmer*, 246–48. These figures are in need of more scholarly attention.

⁵³ Coedès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge* 6:168–69. These three names are all prefixed with the Old Khmer title *vraḥ kaṃmraten añ*; For more on this title, see Vickery, *Society, Economics, and Politics in Pre-Angkor Cambodia*, 143–49.

arly attention. Perhaps one of the reasons for this was the initial lack of corroborative art historical evidence that would justify seeing this single reference to Ekādaśamukha as little more than an inconsequential epithet for Avalokiteśvara. The four tenth-century bronzes of Ekādaśamukha mentioned above, however, appear to indicate that worship and practices surrounding Ekādaśamukha represented new and distinct developments in the cult of Avalokiteśvara in early Cambodia. Overall, the inscription—written in Old Khmer—is concerned with documenting the donation of such things as livestock on behalf of these three figures. What is most interesting is the actual triad itself. Here Avalokiteśvara is depicted not just as representing compassion but also as a higher, more esoteric form that incorporates him as both compassion and wisdom. Ekādaśamukha's supreme hierarchical position in the inscription—a position normally occupied by the Buddha in the epigraphy—appears to indicate that in some circles in tenth-century Cambodia there was no functional difference between this higher form of Avalokiteśvara and a buddha.

Huizhao (651–714 CE) produced a commentary in the early eighth century on a translation of the *EDMD*.⁵⁴ Although outside the geographical context of Southeast Asia, Huizhao's work provides insight into a Buddhist's interpretation of a figure that was also present in Cambodia a few hundred years later. In the introduction of his commentary, Huizhao writes, "The eleven faces [possess] the spiritual power that penetrates the three forms of existence and becomes manifest in the six kinds of renunciation, surpassing even the power of the Buddha himself. Thus has it flowed from time immemorial to the present. It embodies both the dharma-nature and the wonderful mercy and wisdom that fills the miracle body and pervades all things."⁵⁵ Based on this short excerpt, it is not surprising that Ekādaśamukha could represent a greater whole, "surpassing even the power of the Buddha himself." Avalokiteśvara, as Ekādaśamukha, is the embodiment of both compassion and wisdom. In discussing Avalokiteśvara along similar lines, John Holt has written that, "He (Avalokiteśvara) is the collectively embodied (*sangha* [*sic*]) energy of enlightenment (*prajñā* [*sic*] [wisdom] united with *karuṇā* [compassion]) in their affective states of expression and realization. That is, Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara is Buddha and dharma in a collectively realized, temporal state of action."⁵⁶ This embodied whole and its doctrinal implications are directly

⁵⁴ Wood ("Eleven Faces of the Bodhisattva") writes that Huizhao's commentary (*Shiyi mian shenzhou xin jing yishu*) was based on Xuanzang's (ca. 598–664) translation of the *EDMD*, which was completed in 656 CE (14). Huizhao was Xuanzang's disciple. More recently, however, Henrik Sørensen has written that this commentary attributed to Huizhao was based on an unspecified version of the text (Grinstead and Sørensen, "Sūtra of the Eleven-Headed Avalokiteśvara," 98).

⁵⁵ Wood, "Eleven Faces of the Bodhisattva," 374–75.

⁵⁶ John Holt, *Buddha in the Crown: Avalokiteśvara in the Buddhist Traditions of Sri Lanka* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1991), 45.

represented in the inscription's hierarchical order: Ekādaśamukha = Lokeśvara (Compassion) + Bhagavatī (Wisdom).

That said, however, it must be admitted that the evidence for the *EDMD*'s influence in early Cambodia is circumstantial, since the argument is based solely on the iconography of the four bronzes cited above and the appearance of the word *Ekādaśamukha* in the Prasat Chikreng inscription. While one cannot easily dismiss the tantric connections associated with this particular representation of the bodhisattva, on the above evidence alone it is certainly possible that knowledge of the eleven-faced (or eleven-headed) Avalokiteśvara came from another source, or other sources, in which this particular manifestation of the bodhisattva was also present.

THE ELEVEN-HEADED AVALOKITEŚVARA AND THE
KĀRAṆḌAVYŪHA SŪTRA

The eleven-headed form of Avalokiteśvara is also cited in the *KVS*—a Sanskrit text of complex origins that extols the virtues of Avalokiteśvara and that likely took the form familiar to us between the late fourth and early fifth centuries CE in the region of Kashmir.⁵⁷ The earliest surviving manuscripts come from Gilgit and date from a period no later than the seventh century CE.⁵⁸ There are also a large number of surviving manuscripts written in Nepālī and Nevarī scripts, and according to Adelheid Mette some of these manuscripts are dated very early.⁵⁹ The text traditions received by the manuscripts from the area of Nepal are also the source of both the Tibetan and the Chinese translations of the *KVS*.⁶⁰ The *KVS* was brought to Tibet during a period of Buddhist transmission taking place in the late eighth century, and current evidence indicates that a Chinese translation of the text did not take place until the end of the tenth century.⁶¹

⁵⁷ For a short overview regarding the dating of the *KVS*, see Alexander Studholme, *The Origins of Oṃ Maṇipadme Hūṃ: A Study of the Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra* (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 2002): 9–17. Also see Adelheid Mette, “Remarks on the Tradition of the Kāraṇḍavyūha,” in *Aspects of Buddhist Sanskrit, Proceedings of the International Symposium on the Language of Sanskrit Buddhist Texts*, ed. Kāmeśvaranātha Mīśra (Sarnath: Central Institute of Higher Tibetan Studies, 1991), 510–19; Adelheid Mette, *Die Gilgitfragmente des Kāraṇḍavyūha* (Swisttal-Odendorf: Indica et Tibetica, 1997); and Gregory Schopen, “The Ambiguity of Avalokiteśvara and the Tentative Identification of a Painted Scene from a Mahāyāna Sūtra at Ajaṇṭā,” in *Fragments and Fragments of Mahāyāna Buddhism in India: More Collected Papers* (Honolulu: University of Hawai‘i Press, 2005): 278–98, esp. nn. 12 and 13. It should also be noted that throughout this essay I am discussing the earlier prose version of the *KVS*, not the much later verse version, which probably wasn’t written until the fifteenth or sixteenth century (see Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Maṇipadme Hūṃ*, 11, 15).

⁵⁸ Nalinaksha Dutt, *Gilgit Manuscripts*, vol. 1 (Calcutta: Calcutta Oriental Press), 42.

⁵⁹ Mette, “Remarks on the Tradition of the Kāraṇḍavyūha,” 512.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*, 511.

⁶¹ *Ibid.*, 511–12; and Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Maṇipadme Hūṃ*, 15.

The *KVS* has been described as a hybrid text in that it represents a body of work in which the categories of *sūtra* and *tantra* have blurred and overlapped.⁶² Some of the overlapping tantric elements present in the *KVS* are: the initiation into the use of a *mantra* (the famous *Oṃ Mañipadme Hūṃ mantra*), instruction in the creation of a *maṇḍala*, partaking of a consecration ritual (*abhiṣeka*), and the role of a *vidyādhara* (bearer of mantras), all of which also highlight the emphasis on a controlled transfer of special gnosis to a worthy recipient.

Additionally, the text contains unmistakable Śaivite, as well as Vaiṣṇava, purāṇic influences. Examples include, but are not limited to, the appropriation and alteration of purāṇic narratives involving both Śiva and Viṣṇu, the modeling of Avalokiteśvara's *mantra* on that of Śiva's own *Namaḥ Śivāya*, and the transformation of Avalokiteśvara into a Buddhist *īśvara* (lord) in the same vein as the Śiva and Viṣṇu. In this sense, Avalokiteśvara is no longer a generic *lokeśvara* (lord of the world, of which there were many), but the one *Lokeśvara*.

Alexander Studholme has suggested that the *KVS* was written from the point of view of a Mahāyāna monastic establishment essentially coming to grips with the ever-increasing popularity of charismatic tantric practitioners and their powerful methods and rituals.⁶³ It is interesting to note that a very similar context may have made the *KVS* attractive to Mahāyāna monks in Cambodia.

Returning to the eleven-headed form of Avalokiteśvara, we note that the *KVS* contains two references to this aspect of Avalokiteśvara, although the text specifically uses the Sanskrit compound *ekādaśaśīrṣa* (eleven-headed) instead of *ekādaśamukha* (eleven-faced). The first occurrence is found in part 1, chapter 2, during a narrative scene in which Avalokiteśvara visits the Avīci hell in order to alleviate the suffering of the beings reborn there (a scene alluded to several times in the epigraphical and art historical record). Toward the end of the narrative, Yama, who is in awe of Avalokiteśvara's abilities, prostrates himself before the bodhisattva and recites fifty-nine different titles of Avalokiteśvara, one of which is *Ekādaśaśīrṣa*.⁶⁴

⁶² Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Mañipadme Hūṃ*, 13. This observation concerning the overlapping between *sūtra* and *tantra*, however, was made much earlier by David Seyfort Ruegg, who also claimed the *KVS* displayed similarities with another Buddhist tantric text of the *krīyātantra* class, the *Mañjuśrīmūlakalpa*. See David Seyfort Ruegg, "Sur les rapports entre le Bouddhisme et le 'substrat religieux' indien et tibétain," *Journal Asiatique* 252 (1964): 77–95, esp. 84. Max Nihom (*Studies in Indian and Indo-Indonesian Tantrism: The Kuṅjarakarmadharmakathana and the Yogatantra* [Vienna: Sammlung De Nobili Institut für Indologie der Universität Wien, 1994], 139) picks up on Ruegg's observations and slightly expands them.

⁶³ Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Mañipadme Hūṃ*, 85.

⁶⁴ *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, in *Mahāyāna-Sūtra-Saṃgraha*, ed. P. L. Vaidya (Darbhanga: Mathila Institute, 1961), 258–308, 262, line 31. I am fully aware of the problems of Vaidya's edition of the *KVS*, which is based on a late twelfth-century Nepalese manuscript. Unfortunately, however, no

The second reference occurs in the *KVS*, part 2, chapter 2. This section deals with the famous episode detailing the description of Avalokiteśvara's hair pores. The scene describes Avalokiteśvara's omnipresent body as having eleven heads and a hundred thousand arms and eyes.⁶⁵

This eleven-headed form of Avalokiteśvara appears to be one among seven other unique relief carvings depicting scenes from *KVS* on the western side of the second enclosure of Banteay Chhmar—a temple complex located in north-western Cambodia dating from the reign of Jayavarman VII (r. 1182–ca. 1218).⁶⁶ Other scenes from the *KVS* depicted on the wall of this temple—such as the subjugation and conversion of Śiva and Umā and the birth of Hindu deities from the body of Avalokiteśvara—appear to indicate that the *KVS* had become an ideal tool to aid in contesting the supremacy of Śaivism when Jayavarman began to reign in the late twelfth century.⁶⁷ The *KVS*, however, did not obtain this position of privilege overnight. In Cambodia, the roots for dissemination of the text lie in the tenth century.

THE KĀRAṆḌAVYŪHA SŪTRA IN TENTH-CENTURY CAMBODIA AND CAMPA

Although the *KVS* is never mentioned by name in Cambodian sources, there is epigraphical evidence that supports the argument that the text—or one closely related to the *KVS* as we know it today—was well known in Cambodia no later than the mid- to late tenth century. The fact that we do not find evidence for the *KVS* in Cambodia until then corresponds to what is known about the wider transmission of this text into areas such as China. Again, while the text was brought to Tibet during the transmission of Buddhism occurring in

critical edition yet exists for the *KVS*, nor is there any published translation of the text in any modern European language, or even another printed text of the *KVS* (besides the Gilgit fragments). While Mette notes that Vaidya differs from the so-called Nepalese version, she also adds that the “contents and length [i.e., of Vaidya's version] correspond on the whole” (“Remarks on the Tradition of the Kāraṇḍavyūha,” 514).

⁶⁵ Vaidya, *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, 290, line 15. A fair amount of additional detail is devoted to the description of this manifestation, which highlights its importance. An English summary of this scene is found in Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Mañipadme Hūm*, 138. Also note that this description of the eleven-headed Avalokiteśvara is partially preserved in the Gilgit fragments; although only the *e* character from the word *ekādaśaśiṛṣa* remains. See Mette, *Gilgitfragmente*, 74–75.

⁶⁶ These scenes were examined in Louis Finot, “Lokeçvara en Indochine,” *Études Asiatiques* 1 (1925): 227–56. Finot's work was later elaborated on by Jean Boisselier in, “Précisions sur quelques images khmères d'Avalokiteśvara: Les bas-reliefs de Banteay Chmar,” *Arts Asiatiques* 11, no. 1 (1965): 73–89. For images of the reliefs, see plate 141 in Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*. Also note that only two panels are still standing in situ, while two more panels are on site collapsed amid the rubble. In 1998 a large section of wall, consisting of four panels, was stolen. Two of the panels have since been recovered and are now located at the Phnom Penh National Museum. The other two panels remain unaccounted for. I owe special thanks to Joyce Clark for funding and making possible my first trip to Banteay Chhmar. Additional support for follow-up trips came from a fellowship granted through the Center for Khmer Studies.

⁶⁷ For a summary description of the all eight bas-relief panels, see Chutiwongs, *Iconography of Avalokiteśvara*, 222–25.

the late eighth century, it was not brought to China until the late tenth century. Specifically, the Kashmiri T'ien Si Tsai departed for China from the famous Buddhist site of Nālandā in 980 CE; and he would later translate the sūtra into Chinese around 983 CE.⁶⁸ Therefore, the fact that the text may not have come to Cambodia until later in the tenth century actually corresponds to a period of more widespread transmission of the *KVS* occurring between the late eighth and the late tenth centuries. When we recall that around the mid- to late ninth century the northern polity (or polities) of Campā situated around Thu Bồn valley had regained economic and political power with regard to maritime trade on the route between India and China, it is not implausible to suggest that during this period of widespread transmission the *KVS* may have been brought to the mainland via trading outposts in Campā before eventually being transmitted to Cambodia.

The strongest epigraphical support suggesting influence from the *KVS* is found in two inscriptions from Cambodia (K. 417 and K. 1154) and one from Campā (C. 66).⁶⁹ Both Cambodian inscriptions are from the tenth century, while the Campā inscription is dated to the late ninth century.

In a paper presented in 1962, and later published in 1965, Jean Boisselier observed that the opening stanza from K. 417 appeared to be a direct reference to the scene in the *KVS* in which Avalokiteśvara transforms the stove used for tormenting the poor souls of Avīci hell into a lotus pool.⁷⁰ The Sanskrit lines can be translated as “Glory to Lokeśvara, the dust of whose excellent feet thoroughly transformed the vast crackling fires of *avīci* hell into water! Let my obeisance to him who takes away the torments of hell be a thousandfold!” (K. 417, I.1–2).⁷¹ This observation was later supported by scholars such as Max Nihom, who also made connections with the *KVS* in Java.⁷² More recently, Hiram Woodward has argued that a stanza in inscription C. 66—

⁶⁸ The Chinese translation of the text I am discussing in the article is collected in the *Taishō* version of the Chinese Buddhist *Tripiṭaka* as volume number 1050 and as number 782 in the Nanjio, a catalogue of Chinese translations of the Buddhist texts. See Y. Imaeda, “Note Préliminaire sur la Formule Oṃ Maṇi Padme Hūṃ dans les Manuscrits Tibétains de Touen-Houang,” in *Contributions aux Études sur Touen-Houang*, ed. M. Soymie (Genève-Paris: Librairie Droz): 71–76, esp. 71. Also see Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Maṇipadme Hūṃ*, 15.

⁶⁹ Regarding these inscriptions, see tables 1 and 2.

⁷⁰ Boisselier, “Précisions sur quelques images khmères d’Avalokiteśvara,” 81. Vaidya, *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, 262, line 9. For a summary of this episode in English, see Studholme, *Origins of Oṃ Maṇipadme Hūṃ*, 122.

⁷¹ My translation. The Sanskrit reads, “lokeśvaro jayati yasya varāṅghridhūlir āvīcan dhagadh-
ag ity ativrddhavadhnam / nīrīcakāra narakavyasanāpahāre tasmin mādiyanatir astu sahasravāram.”

⁷² Nihom, *Studies in Indian and Indo-Indonesian Tantrism*, 119–41. Yet again we should note the likely regional connections with Java. We should also note that Nihom argues that the *KVS* influenced part of the *Kuṇḍīrakarṇadharmakathana*, a fourteenth- or fifteenth-century Old Javanese didactic poem, which highlights the extent of Buddhist tantric influence in classical Indonesia.

which is connected with the construction of the temple of Đông Dương in Campā—is likely evoking the third chapter of the *KVS* in which Avalokiteśvara liberates the ghost (*preta*) realm: “By day and in the night, men afflicted with suffering—and those men condemned to hell—constantly long for your *darśana*; just as thirsty men tormented by the heat of the sun long for cool water in summer, so too they, tormented by the many sufferings in this land, long to see you” (C. 66, B VIII).⁷³

Finally, perhaps most important is the only epigraphical citation of the *Oṃ Mañipadme Hūṃ mantra* in inscription K. 1154, which dates to the tenth century.⁷⁴ The *mantra* appears for the first time in the *KVS*, and this inscription is the only surviving example of its use in early Cambodia.⁷⁵ The inscription appears on one side of a stele on which an eight-armed Avalokiteśvara is depicted on the other side. The two main hands of the bodhisattva are lowered in *pretasantarpitamudrā*, or the gesture of “satiated hungry ghosts,” which invokes the narrative of Avalokiteśvara entering the city of hungry ghosts (*preta*), whereupon ten rivers flow from his fingers (as well as his toes and pores) in order to restore the deformed creatures’ bodies and satiate their thirst and hunger.⁷⁶ This very same iconographic form of Avalokiteśvara can also

⁷³ My translation. The Sanskrit reads, “duḥkhenābhihatā narāś ca narake kecit tathā narakā rātrau vā ca divā tadā ca satatam kāṅkṣanti te darśanam / tarṣābhīś ca narā divākaraḥatā grīṣme jalam śītaḥ ye te draṣṭum anekaduḥkhavihata vecchanti bhūmau yathā.” Hiram Woodward, “The Temple of Dong Duong and the *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*,” in *From Beyond the Eastern Horizon: Essays in Honour of Professor Lokesh Chandra*, ed. ManjuShree Gupta (New Delhi: Aditya Prakashan, forthcoming). For more of Woodward’s work on the *KVS* in Cambodia, see “Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia,” and Hiram Woodward, “The *Karandavyūha Sūtra* and Buddhist Art in 10th Century Cambodia,” in *Buddhist Art: Form and Meaning*, ed. Pratapaditya Pal (Mumbai: Marg Publications, 2007), 70–83.

⁷⁴ For more on this inscription, see Saveros Pou, *Nouvelles inscriptions du Cambodge*, vols. 2–3 (Paris: École française d’Extrême-Orient, 2002), 129; Woodward, “*Karandavyūha Sūtra* and Buddhist Art,” 72–73; and Peter Skilling, “An *Oṃ Mañipadme Hūṃ* Inscription,” *Aséanie* 11 (2003): 13–20.

⁷⁵ Although the *mantra* is referred to throughout the *KVS*, the actual six-syllable *mantra* occurs only twice. See Vaidya, *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, 297, line 3, and 300, line 23. Although the context differs, the textual counterpart for the six-syllable *mantra* in the Gilgit fragments can be found in the National Archives of India (New Delhi), G1 fol. 46a1; facsimiles are collected in Raghu Vira and Lokesh Chandra, eds., *Gilgit Buddhist Manuscripts (Facsimile Edition)*, parts 7–8 (New Delhi: International Academy of Indian Culture, 1974). See Mette, *Gilgitfragmente*, 87.

⁷⁶ Regarding the identification of the *pretasantarpita* gesture, see Hiram Woodward, “Aspects of Buddhism in Tenth-Century Cambodia” (paper presented at the Conference for Buddhist Dynamics in Premodern Southeast Asia, Singapore, March 10–11, 2011). The narrative of Avalokiteśvara visiting the *preta* city is found in *KVS* 1.3 (Vaidya, *Kāraṇḍavyūha Sūtra*, 263–64). *Pretasantarpita* Lokeśvara is also one of the forms of Avalokiteśvara described in the *Sādhnamālā*, but the iconography described in the *Sādhnamālā* is significantly different from the bodhisattva depicted on the stele. Benoytosh Bhattacharyya, *The Indian Buddhist Iconography: Mainly Based on the Sādhnamālā and Cognate Tātric Texts of Ritual* (1924; Calcutta: Firma K.L. Mukhopadhyay, 1958), 141–42; and Ruriko Sakuma, *Sādhnamālā: Avalokiteśvara Section, Sanskrit and Tibetan Texts* (Delhi: Adroit, 2002), 154. Also see Gouriswar Bhattacharya, “Pretasantarpita-Lokeśvara,” *Journal of Bengal* 6 (2001): 21–44.

be seen on the back of a tenth-century stele now kept in the Bangkok National Museum.⁷⁷

Taken together, these inscriptions (K. 417, C. 66, and K. 1154) offer enough evidence to suggest that the *KVS* was, in one form or another, circulating in the region during the tenth century and had attained a level of popularity with Buddhists and ruling elites. When considering the tantric characteristics of the *KVS*, the attested presence of *Ekādaśamukha* in both epigraphical and art historical sources, and the overt references to tantric texts and practices in inscriptions like that of Vat Sithor and An Thái (both of which reference the bodhisattva), we may conclude that the role of Avalokiteśvara was adapted and reconceptualized around the tenth century to conform to new practices and thoughts espoused in tantric Buddhist circles emerging in tenth-century Cambodia.

CONCLUSION

The evidence discussed is enough to indicate that there was an emerging and developing tantric presence in tenth-century Cambodia, connected in some ways with Avalokiteśvara, that should be explored in more depth. In the case of early Cambodia and Campā, I have demonstrated that there are contemporaneous spikes in the epigraphical records of both regions related to the patronage of forms of Mahāyāna Buddhism, and more specifically to the inclusion of Avalokiteśvara in the inscriptions. In other words, Avalokiteśvara becomes a popular figure of royal devotion and patronage at roughly contemporary times in both Cambodia and Campā. Also at this time, both regions for the first time contain Buddhist tantric elements in the inscriptions indicating that existing forms of Mahāyāna Buddhism in the region were being influenced by and adapted to emerging strains of tantric thought and practice.

Due to the nature of the evidence, which is incomplete and fragmentary, the details of these newly emerging forms of tantric Buddhism are still vague and in need of additional examination. Nevertheless, the common tendency to confine Avalokiteśvara to the overgeneralized category of Mahāyāna Buddhism overlooks the complex and multifaceted role of the bodhisattva. Finally, Mahāyāna Buddhism as a catch-all and static category describing roughly seven centuries of Buddhism in Cambodia oversimplifies a history that was likely characterized by frequent change, development, and innovation by Buddhist practitioners and communities. The evidence presented above from the epigraphical and art historical record highlights just a few examples of such change and development.

University of Florida

⁷⁷ For more on this stele, including plates, see Woodward, “*Karandavyuha Sutra* and Buddhist Art,” 74–78.